calculations himself, to find an auspicious date for the wedding. In September 1541, a year or so after losing his empire and fleeing Lahore, Humayun had won himself a bride.

Abul Fazl maintains a loyal, tight-lipped silence on all the drama that preceded the marriage; all he will say is that Humayun and Hamida's wedding was celebrated 'with lordly ceremonies and royal rites'. He does not say, either, that one member of the royal family found no joy in the occasion. Only Jouher writes of how Hindal marched off 'in an angry mood' towards Qandahar.[35]

Humayun may have triumphed in affairs of the heart, but in affairs of state he was more isolated than ever before. Indeed, in the first year of their marriage, the skirt Hamida could not reach would find itself straggling and torn upon barren ground; and the young bride would have more than one occasion to regret not having clung more firmly to her refusal.

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By the spring of 1542, Humayun's Sindh 'campaign' was in a shambles. He had gained neither military victory nor strategic alliance, and his army – with neither food on their plates nor victory on the horizon – was haemorrhaging. Jouher recounts the pitiful tale of how Humayun had to stay up all night with two of his chiefs, Tardi Beg and Munim Khan, to 'prevent their going off'. In the morning, Humayun left the tent – presumably for his ablutions – but no sooner had he gone than the two men 'ran towards their horses'. Though Humayun's attendants called after them – stop! – they wouldn't listen until Humayun raced into view and 'with great difficulty prevailed on them to return'.

As summer stole upon them, Humayun and his few unhappy adherents took a decision born of desperation: they marched into the arid desert lands of Rajasthan, and the realm of Raja Maldeo of Marwar.

The journey, writes Jouher, was 'horrid'; on one particular leg of it, they marched twenty-seven hours without finding water. Thirst is not a suffering that ennobles; it certainly did not bring out the best in Humayun. Soon after the enfeebled company found water, Humayun rode past a Mongol merchant lying on the road, too weak even to walk to the pond. As it happens, Humayun owed this merchant a great deal of money, and saw a